Wimberley and Martindale Area Study Project

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Table of Contents

- Introduction
- History of Wimberley
- Visiting Wimberley
- History of Martindale
- Visiting Martindale
- Demographics of Wimberley and Martindale
- The Interstate 35 Divide- problems and possible solutions
- Preserving Wimberley in the Population Boom
- Decay and Hope for Martindale
- Conclusion

Introduction

The communities of Wimberley and Martindale will be studied in this paper. Covered with be their history, a description of each town as seen from a visitor, the demographics of each, a discussion on the I-35 divide, and challenges that both towns are facing.

History of Wimberley

What is known today as Wimberley started in the mid 1800's when the population of Texas was growing rapidly. Many settlers in central Texas were Texas Independence veterans holding land grants given to them as gifts of their service. The settlement was originally called Glendale (Wimberley Chamber of Commerce). As of 1948, it was the site of a small trading post settlement. William C. Winters, a San Jacinto veteran, settled in the community in 1856 and built a saw mill and grist mill powered by the flow of Cypress Creek. Glendale then changed its name to "Winters' Mill". (Wimberley Chamber of Commerce)



Figure 1. The Winters-Wimberley House

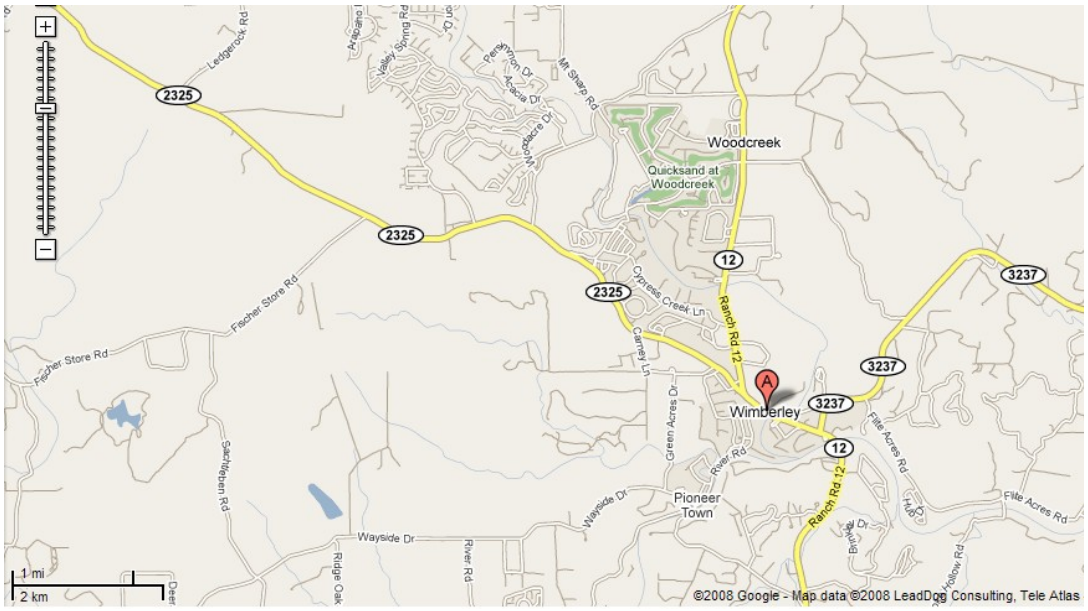
During the civil war, the community contributed to the southern cause by making charcoal on the banks of the Blanco River and extracting bat guano from local caves (Wimberley Chamber of Commerce). These were sent my mules to Austin where sodium nitrate was extracted from bat guano and mixed with other ingredients to make gun powder (Wimberley Chamber of Commerce). After Winters died in 1864, the mills were passed John Cude, his son-in-law (Wimberley Chamber of Commerce). The community was then called "Cude's Mill" (Wimberley Chamber of Commerce). In the 1870's, Pleasant Wimberley moved his family to town. Wimberley contributed to schools and churches in the area along with some of the needy in town. He bought the mills from Cude and the town was then renamed to "Wimberley's Mill" (Wimberley Chamber of Commerce). The town was then renamed "Wimberleyville" and was later changed to "Wimberley". Wimberley increased the mill operation to include a grist mill, flour mill, lumber mill, shingle mill, molasses mill and later a cotton gin (Wimberley Chamber of Commerce). The mills continued operation with the Winters family till 1907 when John Will Pyland bought it (Wimberley Chamber of Commerce). By 1912, the creek could no longer be used to operate the mills and so a 20 horsepower engine was used instead. The mill ceased operation in 1925. (Wimberley Chamber of Commerce)



Figure 2. Cypress Creek Nature Trail near the Town Square

Visiting Wimberley

Wimberley is located in a valley at the junction of Cypress Creek and the Blanco. Surrounding the town are rocky hills with cedar and oak covering the hills. Lining the river and creek are bald cypress and pecan trees. Wimberley is at the junction of Ranch Road 12, FM 2235 and FM 3237. It is located 28 miles southwest of Austin. The heart of the city is located between Cypress Creek and the Blanco River. In the market area, you can see numerous gift shops, bed and breakfasts, restaurants and artist communities. Much of the town spreads out of each the highways going into it. Numerous hills dot the landscape around town. The majority of the growth is between FM2325 and RR12. This includes the community of Woodcreek along of other housing communities nestled in the hills.



Map 1 – Map of Wimberley. Courtesy Yahoo Maps

History of Martindale

Martindale was established by George and Nancy Martindale (Handbook of Texas). The Martindale's moved to Texas from Mississippi in 1851 (Handbook of Texas). Four other families later joined the Martindales (Handbook of Texas). The town was established in 1855 when Nancy Martindale donated the land for the town site (Handbook of Texas). A Baptist church was organized in 1858 (Handbook of Texas). With a population of 50, a post office was established in 1875 (Handbook of Texas).



Figure 3 – Example of Deterioration in Downtown Martindale

By 1890, the town had four general stores and four grist mills and gins and the town reached a population of 200 by 1892 (Handbook of Texas). By 1914, the town had four churches, a hotel, three cotton gins, three stores, a bank, and telephone service (Handbook of Texas). The population reached 500 between 1910 and 1946. The cotton seed and hybrid seed corn companies near Martindale supplied over 65 percent of the hybrid seed corn and a large percentage of the pedigreed cottonseed produced in Texas (Handbook of Texas).



Figure 4 – Numerous Storage Bins of Grain in Downtown Martindale

Over the last fifty years, Martindale's population has been in flux. After reaching a high population of 600 in 1957, it fell to 250 in 1969 and 210 in 1982 when only three businesses were active (Handbook of Texas). The population increased to 1068 by 1988 and eleven businesses were in operation (Handbook of Texas). Through Mrs. Martindale's request, the town has to remain dry and property owned by anyone selling alcohol or gambling in Martindale is subject to revert to the Martindale family (Handbook of Texas). By 2000, the population was at 953 (Handbook of Texas).

Visiting Martindale

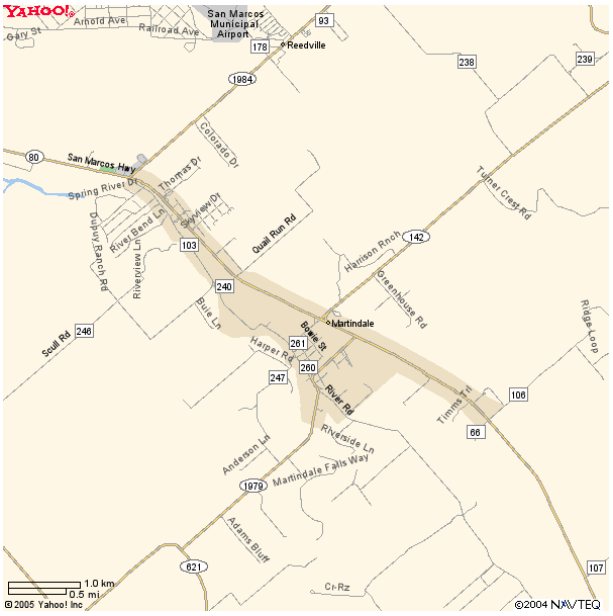
Martindale is located next to the San Marcos River. It core is located off of Highway 80 about six miles east of San Marcos. Not much of Martindale is on Highway 80. A couple of convenience stores and houses are on the south side and mostly farm land is on the north side. River Road cuts through the center of town and goes by a majority of

Martindale's municipal buildings including City Hall. As you drive into Martindale from San Marcos, you can take one of several cross roads from Highway 80 to get to River Road. River Road eventually turns into Main Street. The core of the Martindale is along this stretch of road. The downtown is mostly deserted with empty retail buildings built around the turn of the last century (Figure 3). An abandoned cotton gin and seed company can be seen from Main Street as well. Just off of Main Street though is a neighborhood very much in tact. Driving along Jennings and Bowie Street, you can see many of the original houses and a newly refurbished Methodist Church. A new park opened last year. It has a few play sets for children, a basketball court and a walking trail going to the San Marcos River (Figure 5).



Figure 5 – San Marcos River as seen in Martindale

Going back to San Marcos on highway 80, you see a new development on a street called Skyview Drive. It's mostly a low income community with many manufactured homes.



Map 2- Map of Martindale

Demographics of Wimberley and Martindale and Analysis

Wimberley and Martindale have very contrasting demographics as seen on Table 1. The most startling difference is the racial make up in both towns. Wimberley is over 94 percent Anglo to Martindale's 58 percent. Another startling difference is the median income where Wimberley residents make over $12,000 more dollars a year than Martindale residents. Also significant is that there are over twice the percentage of residents over 65 in Wimberley than in Martindale. This shows how Wimberley has become very popular for retirees. Martindale though is closer to representing Texas and the U.S. in several categories namely average age and percent over sixty five.

2000 US Census Bureau	**Wimberley**	**Martindale**	**Texas**	**US**
Population	3797	953		
Male	47.17%	49.74%	49.6	49.1
Female	52.83%	50.26%	50.4	50.9
Average Age	44.0	32.6	33.9	36.2
Percent White	94.5%	58.8%	71.0%	75.14%
65 Years and over	22.28%	11.02%	9.9%	12.43%
Rent occupied Housing	18.04%	30.36%		30.77%
Median Household Income	$46,042	$33,882		$44,854

Table 1

The Interstate 35 Divide- Problems and Possible Solutions

Throughout central Texas, Interstate 35 roughly follows the Balcones Escarpment which divides what is considered the Hill Country from the typically flat and treeless grassy plains. The highway also serves as an economic, cultural and ethnic divide. The reason why the divide is there has a long history. A century ago, wealthy land owners chose to live in the more aesthetically pleasing Hill Country. The east was used for farming and ranching. Housing for the workers was located near the farms and ranches (Schwartz 2002). These workers were predominately Hispanic (Schwartz 2002). Growth took on different forms in Hays County in the last century as a result of this. The east side saw generations of substandard developments creating a cycle of neglect (Schwartz 2002). In the Hill Country, the land was worth more with the picturesque scenery, so high-end

developments for wealthy urbanites fleeing the city became the norm (Schwartz 2002). Former San Marcos mayor Billy Moor state that “Even when the place was inhabited by Native Americans, they chose to live on the high ground. I think the pattern is pretty consistent.” (Schwartz 2002)

In the 1990’s, the growth of Austin changed the county’s make up drastically. Both sides of the highway saw rapid growth during this time (Schwartz 2002). The fastest growing tracts were in fact east of the highway where most of the residents are coming from Austin (Schwartz 2002). Looking the minority population in particular, Hays County outpaced other state counties median household income (Schwartz 2002). In 1999, the median Hispanic household income was $35,649 which was 19 percent higher than the median income for Hispanics statewide (Schwartz 2002). This does not hide the stark differences between eastern and western Hays County. Two of the three poorest census tracts in Hays County are east of I-35 and the five wealthiest are west of I-35 (Schwartz 2002). The northwest part of the county has the highest concentration of wealth (Schwartz 2002). Wimberley is in this part of Hays County. The 2000 census showed that about a third of the county has a median household income of between $60,000 and $80,000 (Schwartz 2002). The east side had family incomes ranging from $23,000 to $49,000 depending on the census tract (Schwartz 2002). Ethnically, the east is more diverse with Hispanics being the majority in four census tracts as of 2000 as opposed to only two census tracts in 1980 (Schwartz 2002). Whites were the majority in all the census tracts west of I-35 in Hays County.

Many residents east of I-35 want this to change though. Many perceive a lack of political representation as a reason for and result of the economic differences. Many residents feel that officials are slow to respond to their needs whether it's fixing roads or cutting grass at intersections (Schwartz 2002). This in contrast to areas west of I-35 where neighborhoods are very organized. For example, The Friendship Alliance, a collection of neighborhood groups near Dripping Springs, has mobilized residents and has evolved into a powerful political force where local officials pay close attention to (Schwartz 2002). They have a significant voice in the development of their area. Voter participation is significantly lower east of I-35 though (Schwartz 2002). On average, districts east of I-35 have less voter turnout than the county average (Schwartz 2002). Some see a power vacuum in the unincorporated areas of the east side. Jeff Barton, a former county commission for Prescient 2 said that he's seen organizers come in for a few years and leave in frustration or fade away (Schwartz 2002). The Precinct 2 Commissioner, Susie Carter, in 2002 stated the problem is that the county's inability or unwillingness to regulate the type of subdivisions that populate the east side (Schwartz 2002). By contrast, in Wimberley, residents banded together to protest the construction of a low-income housing development eventually killing the project (Schwartz 2002). Some groups in east Hays County have attempted to band together such as the Hays County Tejano Democrats to try to give a common voice to the residents (Schwartz 2002). Carter has been pushing for the county to a adopt a bill (Senate Bill 873) passed by the Legislature that essentially gives counties the same regulatory power over subdivisions that cities have for the extraterritorial jurisdictions by adopting stricter subdivision rules and seize authority given to counties (Schwartz 2002). This would

give the county more power to prevent shoddy developments in the east side. Hays County judge Jim Powers states that once the county adopts this bill, that development could take on a new form in the east side (Schwartz 2002). As he stated "Good developers will want to come and bad developers won't want to come. And we don't want them to come." (Schwartz 2002) UT professor Hamermesh says that as long as there is space to build in western Hays County that builders will choose that side for higher cost subdivisions (Schwartz 2002). As space becomes sparse and property values rise, developers will turn east.

Preserving Wimberley in the Population Boom

According to the 2000 census, seven of the Hill Country's rural counties were among the top 100 fastest-growing counties in the nation (Caputo 2004). Conservation groups are worried that this growth will not only hurt the natural beauty, but put major strains on the natural resources (Caputo 2004). The Blanco River is on top of the Trinity Aquifer which is connected to the Edwards Aquifer both supplying drinking water for the region. The river runs 87 miles through the Hill Country. Most of the land along the river is privately owned and this poses a problem in enforcing activity along the river (Caputo 2004). Hays County in particular saw a 74 percent increase in population from 1990 to 2000 (Caputo 2004). Water is the main issue, but years of overgrazing have already depleted the topsoil and thinned out native vegetation (Caputo 2004). Residents such as Michael and Tracy DiLeo bought a 275 acre ranch on the Blanco with plans to restore the land to its natural state (Caputo 2004). Conservation organizations such as the Nature Conservancy have joined forces to combat these issues (Caputo 2004). Overall,

education and outreach may be a start, but that alone will not solve the problem (Caputo 2004). Massive public support for regulations along the river will be the long term solution.

Decay and Hope for Martindale

Over population is not a problem with Martindale. In fact revitalizing the downtown area has been a hope many Martindale residents. Its downtown is mostly decaying, but the empty buildings occupying downtown are nostalgic and has been a perfect background for an old western town, so movie companies have filmed three movies and a TV miniseries there (Cartwright 2006). It used to be the cotton and cottonseed capital of Central Texas, but it began declining after World War II and virtually became a ghost town when its lone public school closed down in the mid 1960's (Cartwright 2006). Martha Nell is an ex mayor and descendent of the Martindale family. She says that the biggest problem with Martindale is apathy and that no one wants to participate in the community (Cartwright 2006). Help is on the way though. In 2004, Carlton Carl, a lobbyist in Washington DC purchased 36,000 square feet of downtown property. He hopes to build restaurants, grocery stores, gift shops, much like Wimberley, Greene and other towns in the area.

Conclusion

Wimberley and Martindale are two very different towns that have gone in two different directions in the last ten years. With San Marcos growing and with Martindale's proximity to it with a major highway, a running river and a historic downtown, its future

is looking brighter as a community that will grow. Wimberley though has problems of it's own with over population, dwindling water resources and the loss of its natural habitat. If both communities are to keep or improve their quality of life, the citizens must be more involved in how each community grows.

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